

Why Blaming Video Games for Violence is Wrong. [Test S2 2022-2023] / 10
The New York Times, 09/12/2019, 4min1s

1. According to a politician, playing video games deprives us of ... 1
 £ liberty.
 £ our right to vote.
~~£~~ human qualities or attributes.
2. According to the President of the United States, video games are ... 1
~~£~~ horrible and common.
 £ pleasant and attractive.
 £ uninteresting and boring.
3. Charlie Goldberg is ... 1
 £ a danger to society.
~~£~~ an inveterate gamer.
 £ a video game programmer.
4. What type of video games does he enjoy the most? 1
 ø shooter
5. The rate of violent gun deaths is... 1
~~£~~ more important in the USA.
 £ slightly the same everywhere in the world.
 £ proportional to the video sales per person.
6. According to the American Psychological Association, video games... 1
 £ are somehow linked to mass shootings.
 £ are undoubtedly linked to violent crime.
~~£~~ have nothing to do with shootings or crimes.
7. Apart from video games, what is aggression or violence linked to? 1
 (One answer expected among several possibilities)
 ø organized sport

8. In 1915, the Supreme Court ... 1
 £ supported film making.
~~£~~ looked unfavorably at movies.
 £ protected movies from censorship.
9. What did the politicians use to blame between the 50s and the 90s? 1
 (Two answers expected among several possibilities)
 ø paranoias
 ø _____
10. Why shouldn't we pay attention to politicians' arguments about video games? 1
 Would you listen to a book critic who's never read a book

Why Blaming Video Games for Violence is Wrong. [Test S2 2022-2023]

The New York Times, 09/12/2019, 4min1s

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0Eo3La0nA54>

Video games are everywhere nowadays. Invading your living rooms, storming your phones, even taking the blame for society's ills. "These video games dehumanize individuals". Like after the recent wave of shootings when American politicians shared thoughts, prayers, and concerns about videogames. "This was maybe a video game to the evil, demon. He wanted to be a super soldier for his Call of Duty game". Even the President urged us to stop the glorification of violence in our society, including "the gruesome and grisly video games that are now commonplace". Let's debunk this whole "video games cause violence" red herring once and for all.

I'm Charlie Goldberg. I've been reporting on video games for eight years. I've been a lifelong video game player. I have amassed nearly two million subscribers on my gaming YouTube channel. And, well, I play a lot of video games. The violent ones, the shooter ones, more specifically. I also love LEGOs. I'm a father. I know I'm just one gamer, but I'm not a threat to society, and neither are the millions of other people who play video games.

Let's take a look at the world of evidence. American video sales per person are on similar levels to countries like South Korea, Japan or Germany. But our rate of violent gun deaths is 10 to 100 times higher than any of those countries. Even within America, there is zero empirical evidence that video games are linked to mass shootings. Decades of research from the American Psychological Association have shown there's no link between playing violent video games and participating in violent crime. "This all looks nominal". No link, no evidence.

Now, it's true that some research shows a relationship between video games and aggression, but aggression is also linked to lots of things, including organized sports. Now, maybe you're thinking, what about Columbine? Didn't the two shooters in that also play the violent video game Doom? And yes, they did, but violent criminals also watch movies, they read books and digest the news, real or fake. As one A.P.A.¹ expert put it, "the data on bananas causing suicide is about as conclusive". In fact, in 2017, an A.P.A. committee issued a statement discouraging politicians and journalists from trying to connect video games and shooting, precisely because they feared the rhetoric would distract us from addressing issues that we know contribute to real-world violence.

So why, against the objections of science and ethics, do politicians still insist on deflecting our attention? Because it's easy. It works. And it's time tested. In 1915, the Supreme Court supported censorship of movies because they could "cause evil". Film didn't become a form of protected speech until the 50's, just when politicians turned their energies to a new scapegoat: comic books. Now, fast forward to the paranoias about heavy metal in the 1960's, Dungeons and Dragons in the 80's, hip-hop in the 90's. "Here we go again".

Solutions are hard and we like simple answers to complicated questions. And it doesn't take much to get disgruntled parents frustrated by their kids' screen time and Fortnite addiction to believe that video games are evil. The fact that politicians are so removed from video game culture is another reason we should ignore their deflections. Would you listen to a book critic who's never read a book?

Gamers don't really have an issue deciphering fantasy from the real world. But politicians seem to have lost themselves in a politically convenient fiction. Just when we need them to focus on the crisis of our reality.

¹ A.P.A. : American Psychological Association